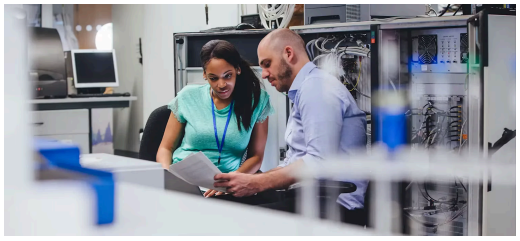
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What Is a Network Administrator? A Career Guide

Written by Coursera Staff • Updated on Jul 23, 2026
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Network administrators make sure the computer networks of an organization are secure and working well.



Key takeaways

- A network administrator is an IT professional who maintains, secures, and troubleshoots an organization’s computer networks.
- Network administrator jobs typically include installing and configuring routers, switches, and firewalls, securing networks, managing VPNs, and resolving connectivity issues.
- To become a network administrator, you can begin in help desk roles and move into networking by building hands-on skills or earning certifications such as CCNA or CompTIA Network+.

Some of the skills you need as a network administrator include understanding network security components, configuring and upgrading servers, and communicating effectively with team members. Explore the role of a

network administrator, how to become one, and your potential salary. Afterward, consider enrolling in the Google IT Support Professional Certificate. In as little as three months, you can learn to perform day-to-day IT support tasks, including computer assembly, wireless networking, installing programs, and customer service.



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What is a network administrator?

A network administrator is an information technology (IT) professional. Their job is to secure, maintain, and troubleshoot computer networks, which are groups of computers sharing information. Organizations employ network administrators to ensure their networks operate efficiently and meet business requirements.

What does a network administrator do?

Responsibilities you may find in a network administrator's job description include:

- Install, configure, and maintain network hardware and software such as routers, firewalls, and switches
- Protect networks from unauthorized users through physical and technical means
- Set up and maintain virtual private networks (VPN)
- Resolve network connectivity issues for other employees
- Maintain and troubleshoot storage networks

Network administrator job descriptions are often similar to system administrators.

System administration vs. network administration

Despite the many overlapping responsibilities, these roles have their differences as well. System administrators focus more on computer systems as a whole, including servers, operating systems, and hardware. Network administrators specialize in network-related tools and tasks, such as IP addresses, routing, and configuring and maintaining local area networks (LANs). It is not uncommon to see competencies from both fields listed under the same job description.



How much does a network administrator get paid?

As of July 2026, the median total salary for a network administrator in the US is $100,000 [1]. This figure includes base salary and additional pay, which may represent commissions, bonuses, profit sharing, or other compensation.

How to become a network administrator

Network administrators often begin their careers in entry-level IT roles, such as help desk technicians. To start down the career path of a network administrator, you'll need to build foundational networking skills. Fifty-five percent of network administrators have a bachelor's degree, 30 percent have an associate degree, and 7 percent have a master's degree [2].

Degrees can boost your earning potential and prepare you for entry-level roles, but employers don't always require them. You have other options if you don't plan on pursuing a degree. For example, you can use networking certifications to gain essential skills and demonstrate your abilities to employers. You can learn about core network administration skills in the following section.

Learn more: How to Become a Help Desk Technician in 3 Steps

Key network administrator skills

- **Knowledge of different types of networks:** Network types include local area networks (LANs), wide area networks (WANs), virtual private networks (VPNs), and sometimes storage area networks (SANs). Though some jobs may require more experience in one over another, having a basic understanding of the various network types and how to configure them will be crucial to your network administrator skill set.
- **Understanding of network security components:** These include firewalls, VPNs, and access control. Knowing about common cyberattacks and the appropriate response to them is critical for a network administrator.
- **Familiarity with servers:** Upgrading and configuring servers is a sought-after skill for network administrators. Windows and Linux servers are standard in the US.
- **Communication and teamwork:** As a network administrator, you'll likely work on a team or with other organization members to ensure that computers and systems are running smoothly. Being able to communicate problems and solutions with other people is a valuable skill to have.



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Popular network administrator certifications

The following certifications can be helpful to those in the beginning stages of their networking career:

- **Cisco Certified Network Associate (CCNA):** The CCNA validates your skills in Cisco network solutions, basic IP addressing, and other network fundamentals. Though exam takers usually have some experience working with Cisco networking products, a training program can prepare you for the exam if you're starting from scratch.
- **CompTIA Network+:** The CompTIA Network+ certification covers a wide range of networking basics, such as security, troubleshooting, and infrastructure. It is a solid option for those looking for entry-level networking positions and is generally considered more fundamental than the CCNA. The Network+ can be a good option if you're completely new to networking concepts.

Entry-level network administrator jobs

Many IT professionals get their start in help desk positions, entry-level IT jobs such as IT specialist, help desk technician, help desk analyst, or IT technician that help resolve computer issues that arise for companies and their employees. These positions can give you a broad introduction to the world of IT and give you some

hands-on experience dealing with network issues. Once you have some experience, you can look to transition to a networking position.

Already in a help desk position? If you have an entry-level IT job but hope to switch to network administration, try building up your network skills. You can do this through hands-on experience or by earning a network certification like the CCNA. You can also approach your employer to see if they'll let you take on more network-related tasks or shadow network professionals at your organization.

Interview questions for network administrator jobs

Get ready for an interview by reviewing potential questions. Here are a few basic ones you might run into:

- What is a firewall, and how would you implement one?
- What is a proxy server?
- What is a switch?
- What types of networks are you familiar with?
- Describe a network challenge that you've faced and how you overcame it.

Preparing for IT interviews: IT jobs are highly technical, so an interviewer will probably ask you a combination of technical questions and personal behavioral questions. Have answers ready for both. Prepare professional stories of how you've worked through networking solutions, of your successes, or of when things didn't go so well (and what you did about it). Practice explaining networking processes out loud. It'll help you feel prepared and show employers you're serious about the job.



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